

Degrees of DEBATE

The foreign educational institution bill could make it to Parliament soon, but that may be only the first step in a long and painful journey

By Shafi Rahman

It is said the Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan thought his foreign scholars to be worth more than all the jewels he owned. But for Kapil Sibal, Human Resource Development (HRD) Minister and MP from Chandni Chowk, the high street of Mughal power, this history lesson finds no resonance as he pursues his dream of bringing foreign universities to India. Tough questions and outright opposition from politicians and educationists may well stymie Sibal's revolution-in-a-box.

The immediate challenge for the Government is to make sure the Foreign Educational Institution (Regulation of Entry and Operation) Bill, 2010, part of the Government's frenzy of legislation aimed at a makeover of higher education, passes through Parliament. It is rolling out the red carpet for foreign universities at a time when the country needs 800 to 1,000 new universities within 10 years to increase the proportion of students seeking higher education from the current abysmal rate of 12 per cent to 30. Even though 100 per cent foreign direct investment through the automatic route has been permitted in the education sector since 2000, foreign educational institutions are still not allowed to grant degrees in the country.

The Bill has been opposed by the

Left parties from the beginning. "The UPA Government is creating another special education zone which could harm the interests of weaker sections and lead to the commercialisation of education. Education is going to be an issue where a new confrontation of haves and have-nots is going to emerge," says CPI leader and Rajya Sabha MP D. Raja.

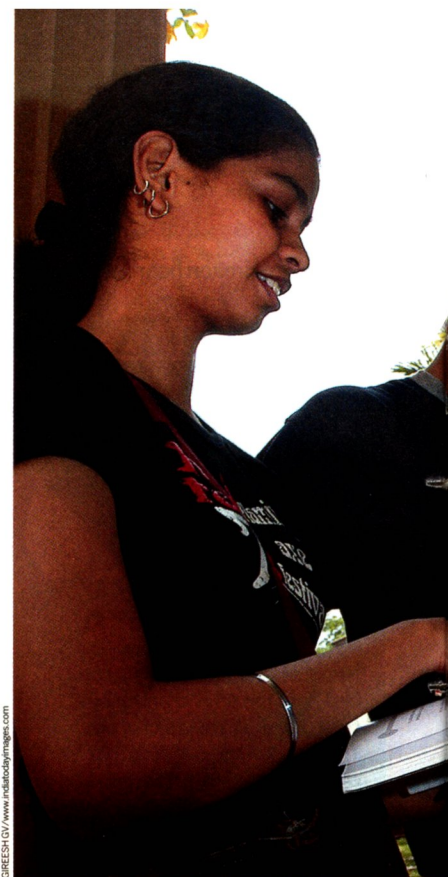
The Left's diminished presence in the 15th Lok Sabha has emboldened the Government to push the Bill. Worried by a lack of numbers in the Rajya Sabha, however, it has been trying to reach out to the BJP. Sibal met BJP leader Murlu Manohar Joshi recently to garner support for the Bill. The BJP says the Bill could damage the education system and that it wouldn't allow its hasty passage.

The Government wants to give wings to the Bill as it believes the entry of foreign universities will help increase accessibility of students to higher education. "The questions being raised are political. We should look at it from an academic viewpoint. We should be pro-students," says Sibal. He does have a point: one out of 150



"The questions being raised on the Bill are mainly political. We should look at it from an academic point of view. We should be pro-students."

KAPIL SIBAL, HUMAN RESOURCE DEVELOPMENT MINISTER



WHO'S AF

HEALTH MINISTRY

- Allowing foreign educational institutions may lead to exodus of trained medical faculty because of higher salaries they offer
- There is a need to build adequate safeguards to retain trained and experienced faculty
- Wants to ensure that the foreign educational institutions train more Indian students rather than foreigners so that their services can be utilised within the country

H R D M I

Not ready to build safeguards to stop flight of faculty, saying factors like job security are also important. Not ready for cap on intake of foreign students.